Indian attack on its nuclear weapons or command and control. This scenario would be especially threatening when combined with India's growing air defense capabilities, which will be able to shoot down Pakistani bombers with increasing effectiveness.[15] An Indian first strike on Pakistan would be extremely dangerous; even a few surviving Pakistani nuclear weapons could inflict untold damage on India's civilian and military infrastructure. Unfortunately, such a scenario is not impossible. A risk-prone Indian decision maker in the midst of a crisis might be tempted to launch first, gambling that Indian conventional and nuclear advantages, combined with missile defense, could limit Indian damage to acceptable levels while destroying Pakistan as a viable entity.

Given the violence of the two countries' past relationship, Pakistani leaders are likely to seriously consider such a possibility and respond accordingly. This would almost certainly entail augmenting Pakistan's nuclear arsenal. As Pakistani defense analyst Ayesha Siddiqa argues, in the event that India acquires BMD capability, Pakistan will "seek to increase the number of missiles to make sure it has enough to evade the [Indian] shield."[16] In addition, Pakistani leaders could escalate to the strategic level more quickly in a crisis, fearing that they might lose their nuclear weapons to an Indian first-strike and BMD capability if they do not use them quickly. As Dinshaw Mistry argues, "As long as the India-Pakistan region is crisis prone, . . . [missile defense] will be destabilizing because it undermines crisis stability."[17]

An Indian BMD system's effects on China might be similar, though probably significantly less severe given the size of China's nuclear arsenal. The Chinese possess approximately 240 nuclear warheads.[18] Thus an Indian missile defense capability, particularly if it was limited in scope, would be considerably less threatening to the Chinese than it would be to the Pakistanis. Still, India's ability to reduce the efficacy of a Chinese second-strike capability could lead the Chinese to increase the size of their nuclear arsenal and could also make them more likely to strike first in the event of a crisis.[19] China could also respond to Indian BMD by renewing its nuclear and ballistic missile transfers to Pakistan, in an effort to offset Indian capabilities and bolster Beijing's long-standing ally.[20] Such negative